GSTIN : 08AABCF7366A1ZT
CIN : U74140RJ2011PTC054922

Frontier Markets®
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To Whom It May Concern,

It is with immense pleasure that I write in support of Mehak Dhawan, a young social innovator in Grade 12, at Jumeirah College, Dubai whose work through DigiSakhi has left a lasting impact on Frontier Markets and our rural women entrepreneur network.

At Frontier Markets, we have spent over a decade building technology-enabled livelihoods for rural women through our 'Meri Saheli' platform, which today supports a network of more than 50,000 digitally enabled women entrepreneurs across 4 states. Working at this scale has taught me that successful technology is rarely defined by its sophistication. It is defined by whether people with limited time, varying literacy levels, and competing responsibilities actually adopt it. Mehak earned my attention because she approached this challenge with the same mindset.

When Mehak first reached out to us in August of 2025, DigiSakhi had already begun as a pilot through which she had trained approximately 25 women in practical digital skills including AI tools, Canva, website creation, and digital portfolios, with several participants already securing freelance opportunities. Rather than asking us to replicate those workshops, she came with a far more important question: *How can digital education be redesigned so that it reaches thousands of women who will never sit in a classroom?* That was a problem worth solving.

What distinguished Mehak throughout this process was not simply execution, but her willingness to improve the product based on field realities. As the programme expanded, our teams challenged assumptions around language, content length, and digital familiarity. Rather than defending her original approach, she simplified the curriculum, reduced complexity, and consistently asked what women would actually use rather than what appeared comprehensive. That ability to prioritize adoption over novelty is uncommon and reflects genuine product maturity.

I also watched her thinking evolve. DigiSakhi began as an initiative focused on digital literacy; it gradually became a platform centered on economic participation. Mehak increasingly viewed AI, design tools, and digital platforms not as skills to be taught, but as practical instruments through which women could market products, secure freelance work, improve productivity, and generate income. That shift, from teaching technology to enabling livelihoods, substantially strengthened both the initiative and its long term relevance.

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We subsequently worked with Mehak to integrate DigiSakhi's learning content into the Meri Saheli ecosystem, allowing elements of her curriculum to travel through an established last-mile network rather than remain confined to standalone workshops. Through this collaboration, supplemented by more than 20 workshops and community interventions across 3–4 states, DigiSakhi's consolidated outreach has now crossed 15,000 women. The number is impressive; the learning behind it interested me more.

As DigiSakhi travelled beyond its original cohort, Mehak encountered precisely the complexities that make last-mile technology difficult: different levels of digital literacy, language preferences, uneven familiarity with AI, limited attention spans, and enormous variation in what "entrepreneurship" means to different women. One conversation remains with me. While reviewing the curriculum, our field team encouraged Mehak to remove several topics she felt were important. Her response was not to defend the content, but to ask a simple question: *"What will help a woman earn sooner?"* She returned with shorter modules, clearer learning pathways, and a stronger product. That moment reflected the quality I value most in founders: the discipline to let users shape the solution.

Over the course of our collaboration, I came to regard Mehak not simply as someone developing educational content, but as a thoughtful builder who understands that meaningful innovation lies at the intersection of technology, human behaviour, and accessibility. She combines intellectual curiosity with careful listening, and ambition with an uncommon willingness to iterate. She possesses the curiosity to build, the humility to listen, and, increasingly, the judgment to understand the difference between reaching people and genuinely creating access for them.

I am pleased to endorse Mehak Dhawan and DigiSakhi, and I believe she has only begun exploring what can be achieved when technology, entrepreneurship, and thoughtful last-mile design are brought together.

Warm regards,

Sushmita Ganguly

Manager – HR & Administration